

Literature Review

Consumer Perceptions of AI: Appreciation Vs Aversion

Introduction and Background

Consumer perceptions of artificial intelligence (AI) have become a central focus in psychology and marketing as AI systems are no longer confined to back-end analytics but now actively shape consumer decisions, experiences, and interactions. This shift challenges fundamental assumptions about expertise, trust, and adoption. Foundational research suggests that people evaluate AI through competing lenses: on one hand, algorithms are perceived as more consistent, objective, and capable; on the other, they are seen as lacking human qualities such as warmth, intentionality, and moral judgment (Jussupow et al., 2020; Jussupow et al., 2024). As AI evolves from predictive systems to generative and interactive agents, these tensions intensify, raising new questions about how consumers interpret AI's role in producing, recommending, and co-creating outcomes (Hermann & Puntoni, 2024; Li et al., 2025). When AI acts not just as a tool but as an “actor,” consumers must reconcile its functional advantages with concerns about trust, control, and authenticity.

This review synthesizes findings from ~60 empirical and conceptual papers drawn from major academic databases that focus on consumer-facing AI across marketing, psychology, and human-AI interaction research. Three core themes form the structure of this review: (1) AI appreciation versus aversion, examining when and why consumers prefer or reject AI; (2) context-dependent and individual differences, highlighting how task characteristics, personality, and perceived risks and benefits shape AI evaluations; and (3) agency, autonomy, and control, exploring how consumers negotiate influence and responsibility in interactions with increasingly autonomous systems. Together, this review develops a more cohesive account of how competence, context, and perceived agency jointly shape consumer perceptions of AI and how these dynamics inform future research on human-AI interaction.

Methodology

The review draws from systematic searches across major academic databases (Google Scholar, JSTOR, ScienceDirect, ResearchGate, and UofT Libraries) using keywords such as *human-AI interaction*, *user perception*, *AI adoption*, *perceived competence and agency*, and *AI appreciation/aversion*. Approximately 150 articles were screened based on relevance to psychological and context-dependent evaluations of AI. After removing duplicates and extraneous topics, 58 studies were included and grouped into thematic clusters and additional literature, from which dominant concepts and relationships were extracted for synthesis.

Thematic Review and Synthesis

Theme 1: AI Appreciation Vs Aversion

A central tension in the literature is the coexistence of algorithm aversion and algorithm appreciation, with recent work suggesting these are not opposing phenomena but contextually activated responses. Foundational evidence shows that individuals systematically penalize algorithms after observing them err, even when their overall performance exceeds that of humans (Dietvorst et al., 2015). This asymmetry reflects a heightened sensitivity to machine error, which Casey (2025) argues is less about inherent distrust of algorithms and more about a baseline preference for human judgment that becomes especially salient under uncertainty. However, this aversion is directly challenged by evidence of algorithm appreciation. Logg et al. (2019) demonstrate that, in many judgment contexts, individuals actually prefer algorithmic over human advice, particularly when the task emphasizes accuracy and expertise. This creates a clear contradiction: while Dietvorst et al. (2015) highlight error-driven rejection, Logg et al. (2019) show default preference under conditions of perceived competence. Hou and Jung (2021) reconcile this tension by suggesting that perceptions of “who counts as an expert” determine reliance; algorithms are favoured when framed as domain experts, but rejected when their authority is ambiguous or contested.

Recent work refines this further by identifying key moderating mechanisms. Qin et al. (2025) propose a capability-personalization framework, arguing that appreciation emerges when AI is seen as highly capable, whereas aversion arises when personalization and thus perceived human relevance, is lacking. This helps explain why Rix et al. (2025) find an “algorithm discount” in consumer valuation: even when algorithm-generated outputs are objectively comparable, they are valued less because they lack perceived human input or intentionality. In contrast, Choung et al. (2024) show that in fairness-sensitive contexts (e.g., hiring), algorithms may be preferred precisely because they are seen as less biased than humans. These findings suggest that consumers trade off competence against human-like qualities such as intentionality, fairness, and personalization.

Situational severity further complicates this relationship. Filiz et al. (2023) find that algorithm aversion intensifies in high-stakes decisions, where the perceived cost of error is greater. This contrasts with settings where stakes are lower or outcomes are easily reversible, in which algorithm reliance is more readily accepted. Importantly, this indicates that error tolerance is not fixed but scales with perceived risk, helping explain why the same individual may both trust and reject AI across different domains. While early work implicitly assumed algorithm aversion to be universal, Liu et al. (2023) demonstrate that its magnitude varies significantly across countries and individual-level traits. This challenges the generalizability of earlier findings by Dietvorst et al. (2015), suggesting that what appears to be a cognitive bias may instead be partially shaped by cultural attitudes toward technology, authority, and uncertainty.

Overall, the literature converges on the idea that AI appreciation and aversion are not competing explanations but dynamically coexisting responses. Aversion is most likely when users focus on errors, lack of personalization, or high-stakes consequences, whereas appreciation emerges when AI is framed as competent, fair, and expert. The key implication is that consumer evaluations are not inherently anti-AI but are shaped by how AI is positioned relative to human judgment, particularly along dimensions of expertise, intentionality, and risk.

Theme 2: Individual Differences and Context-Dependent Perceptions

Building on the appreciation-aversion tension, the literature consistently shows that consumer perceptions of AI are highly contingent on both task characteristics and individual differences. A foundational distinction emerges between utilitarian and hedonic contexts. Longoni and Cian (2020) demonstrate a “word-of-machine” effect, where AI recommendations are preferred in functional, utility-driven tasks but devalued in hedonic or experiential domains. This aligns with Castelo et al. (2019), who find that algorithm aversion is not universal but task-dependent: algorithms are favoured for objective, data-driven decisions but avoided in subjective contexts requiring intuition or taste. However, this pattern is not absolute. Jin and Zhang (2023) show that AI recommendations can outperform human ones in influencing consumer choices even in less strictly utilitarian settings, particularly when AI is perceived as more knowledgeable or data-driven. This contrasts

with Kaiser et al. (2025), who argue that a general preference for human input persists across contexts, suggesting that even when AI demonstrates competence, consumers may still default to human judgment due to social or psychological biases. The implication is that task type alone cannot fully explain preferences; rather, it interacts with how expertise and credibility are framed.

Perceptions of warmth and competence offer nuance to these dynamics. Gilad et al. (2021) find that AI systems that are high in perceived competence but low in warmth are preferred for analytical tasks, whereas human agents are favoured when warmth is salient. This helps explain why Mazzù et al. (2025) observe differential consumer reactions to AI versus human recommendations: even when outcomes are similar, the perceived source influences engagement and product evaluation. In contrast, Alessandro et al. (2024) extend this by introducing a broader social lens, showing that perceptions of AI are shaped by trade-offs between social value and social risk. While some consumers view AI as efficient and beneficial, others associate it with broader societal concerns (e.g., job displacement), which dampens acceptance even in otherwise favourable contexts.

Furthermore, Kaya et al. (2024) demonstrate that personality traits and AI anxiety significantly influence attitudes, with more open or technologically confident individuals showing greater acceptance, while those high in anxiety exhibit resistance. This is complemented by Schwesig et al. (2023), who show perceived risk-opportunity trade-offs are central: individuals who perceive AI as offering more benefits than risks are substantially more willing to adopt it. This risk perception can override task-based preferences, suggesting that even in utilitarian contexts where AI should be preferred, high perceived risk can lead to rejection.

These findings collectively challenge binary interpretations of human versus AI preference. Some studies emphasize stable contextual patterns, while others show that these preferences are malleable and can shift when AI's value proposition is made salient. This highlights that consumer preferences are shaped by how tasks are framed, how AI is positioned, and how different individuals perceive associated risks and benefits. The key implication is that acceptance of AI cannot be predicted by any single factor; instead, it depends on how these elements align in a given decision context.

Theme 3: Agency, Autonomy, and Control

A growing body of research examines how consumers perceive agency and control in interactions with AI, highlighting that autonomy is a key psychological construct shaping acceptance. At a broad level, Catena (2026) conceptualizes AI autonomy as a continuum, arguing that increasing system independence fundamentally shifts responsibility and decision ownership away from users. This is echoed by Pagliari et al. (2022), who frame human-AI interaction through “social agency,” suggesting that users often treat AI as quasi-social actors, thereby heightening sensitivity to issues of influence and control. However, the effects of autonomy are not uniform. Oh et al. (2025), drawing on psychological reactance theory, show that higher AI autonomy can trigger resistance when users feel their freedom to choose is constrained. This contrasts with Cho and Rha (2026), who find that autonomy can enhance satisfaction, but only when users perceive themselves as retaining meaningful control over AI-driven recommendations. The key distinction is not autonomy per se, but whether autonomy is perceived as augmenting or replacing user agency. This helps reconcile seemingly conflicting findings: autonomy increases acceptance when it is experienced as supportive, but decreases it when it is perceived as coercive.

Empirical work on human-AI collaboration further refines this tension. Zhang et al. (2025) show that effective co-creation emerges when agency is distributed rather than centralized, with users preferring interactive systems that allow iterative input and adjustment. Similarly, Feng and Sun (2025) find that generative AI enhances consumer empowerment when it enables collaboration, creativity, and self-expression. Yet, this stands in contrast to Fu et al. (2025), who demonstrate that reliance on large language models can shift users' locus of control outward, potentially reducing perceived personal agency over time. The implication is that while short-term interactions may feel empowering, prolonged reliance on highly capable AI systems could paradoxically erode users' sense of autonomy.

De Freitas et al. (2023) show that attitudes toward AI are strongly shaped by underlying factors such as perceived control, transparency, trust, and understanding. When AI systems are perceived as opaque “black boxes,” users are less likely to feel in control, amplifying resistance. This aligns with broader findings that perceived, not actual, control is the critical driver of acceptance. Moreover, Utami and Aimin (2026) highlight that AI-driven personalization increases perceived value and relevance, but simultaneously raises concerns about data use and surveillance. This creates a tension between convenience and autonomy: while personalization can make users feel understood, it can also make them feel monitored or manipulated. This tension mirrors earlier findings in Theme 1 (personalization vs. capability), suggesting that perceptions of agency are deeply intertwined with broader evaluations of AI’s role.

Overall, this literature suggests that perceptions of agency are central to AI acceptance, mediating how users interpret system behaviour, evaluate outcomes, and assign responsibility. While some work emphasizes the risks of excessive automation, others highlight the benefits of collaborative, user-centered AI. The apparent contradiction underscores a key insight: consumers do not simply prefer more or less autonomy; they prefer appropriately calibrated autonomy that preserves their sense of control while enhancing outcomes.

Discussion

Across the three themes, a coherent pattern emerges: consumer perceptions of AI are not rigid, rather they are conditional evaluations shaped by trade-offs between competence, warmth, and agency. While earlier work framed responses in terms of algorithm aversion versus appreciation, the broader literature suggests a more dynamic process in which consumers continuously evaluate what AI does, how it does it, and what role it plays. For instance, perceptions of competence consistently drive acceptance, yet this is counterbalanced by deficits in warmth, moral judgment, and transparency (McKee et al., 2023; Oliveira et al., 2024). This tension is further reinforced by evidence that consumers engage in “vigilant trust,” simultaneously relying on AI while actively monitoring its risks and limitations (Ding et al., 2026). As a result, acceptance is rarely absolute; instead, it reflects a negotiated balance between perceived benefits and concerns.

A second key pattern is that these evaluations are highly context-sensitive and moderated by both situational and psychological factors. Task type, perceived threat, and domain characteristics shape baseline preferences (Wien & Peluso, 2021; Gursoy et al., 2019), but these are further filtered through individual differences such as trust propensity, prior experience, and AI literacy (Gerlich, 2023; Yigitcanlar et al., 2022). Importantly, emerging evidence suggests that how AI is presented can override these baseline tendencies. For example, revealing whether content is AI- or human-generated can significantly alter perceptions of trust and quality, even when the output itself is identical (Jain et al., 2024). Similarly, hybrid human-AI systems often outperform either source alone in fostering trust and decision confidence (Li & Ha, 2026), suggesting that consumers do not necessarily seek to replace humans with AI, but rather to integrate both in complementary ways.

A third and increasingly dominant theme is the centrality of agency and control. Acceptance is shaped less by AI’s objective capabilities and more by whether users feel they retain meaningful influence over outcomes. This aligns with findings that explainability and transparency enhance trust by restoring perceived control (Chuan et al., 2024), while opaque or overly autonomous systems can trigger resistance. At the same time, generative AI introduces new dynamics: it can increase perceived value through creativity and personalization (Hao et al., 2025), yet also raises concerns about authorship, authenticity, and privacy (Choi et al., 2025). Some studies even suggest that increased competence may encourage greater self-disclosure and reliance (Gieselmann & Sassenberg, 2023), while others highlight growing awareness of privacy risks, indicating a tension between engagement and caution.

Despite these advances, several gaps and contradictions remain. First, much of the literature relies on controlled experiments or short-term interactions, limiting insight into how perceptions evolve with sustained, real-world use (Chen et al., 2025; Hassan et al., 2024). Second, findings remain fragmented across domains, with limited integration between

consumer behaviour, HCI, and ethical perspectives (Bonicalzi et al., 2023; Pypenko, 2023). Third, while generative AI is rapidly reshaping user experiences, existing frameworks that largely developed around predictive or decision-support systems do not fully capture issues of creativity, identity, and co-authorship (Ribeiro et al., 2025). Additionally, much of the empirical work remains concentrated in Western or student samples, raising concerns about cultural and demographic generalizability (Brauner et al., 2025).

These limitations point to several directions for future research. There is a need for longitudinal and field-based studies that capture how trust, reliance, and agency evolve over time. The field would benefit from more integrative models that jointly account for competence, warmth, risk perception, and perceived control rather than treating them in isolation. Furthermore, future work can examine relational framings of AI, moving beyond tool-based perspectives to consider AI as a social actor embedded in broader interaction contexts. In this regard, research on AI's social roles, as an advisor, partner, or servant, can be directly contextualized within these findings. The literature suggests that these roles likely map onto different configurations of agency, competence, and warmth. An "advisor" role may emphasize expertise while preserving user control, aligning with conditions that foster algorithm appreciation. A "partner" role introduces shared agency and co-creation, which may enhance engagement but also raise concerns about autonomy and responsibility. In contrast, a "servant" role may maximize user control but potentially underutilize AI's perceived competence. Importantly, the effectiveness of each role will likely depend on task context, user traits, and perceived risk, reinforcing the broader conclusion that consumer acceptance is shaped by how AI is positioned within a social and decision-making hierarchy.

Conclusion

Together, the literature suggests that AI acceptance can be understood as the outcome of interacting evaluations of competence, social perception, risk, and perceived agency. Consumer perceptions consistently depend on how AI is framed, the role it occupies, and the degree of control they retain in the interaction. The field has progressed from identifying algorithm aversion to a more nuanced understanding of conditional acceptance, where trust, reliance, and resistance coexist and shift across situations. However, gaps remain in integrating these insights across domains and in accounting for emerging forms of AI. Overall, this review highlights that successful AI adoption depends on designing systems that align with human expectations of expertise, transparency, and control. Understanding these dynamics is essential for advancing both theory and practice in human-AI interaction.

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